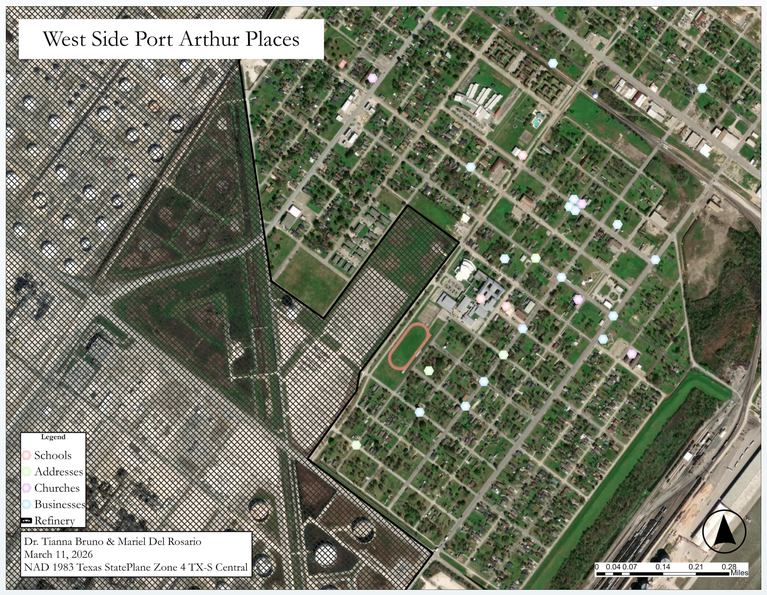
This Place is Our Archive: The Storymap

Dr. Tianna Bruno | Mariel Del Rosario
University of California, Berkeley, Department of Geography

Introduction

The West Side of Port Arthur, Texas is a historically Black community that has faced climate and environmental injustice for generations. It is the site of the **largest refinery** in North America, with several other major refineries and petrochemical facilities alongside it. In the mid-20th century, the primarily Black West Side Port Arthur developed its own resources and networks to become a **thriving and self-sufficient community** even in the midst of segregation. However, with the continuing expansion of local oil refineries, economic disinvestment, and the steep costs of post-disaster recovery, countless businesses, homes, schools, and churches have disappeared with nearly no traces left –**where there were once places, are now spaces.** This project aims to preserve the longstanding Black relationships to the places built and destroyed, but not forgotten, in the West Side of Port Arthur.



Sample of the map of Black-owned businesses, homes, churches, and schools that used to exist in West Side Port Arthur in ArcGIS Pro Layout.

Port Arthur, Texas is the location of the largest refinery in North America, the Motiva Refinery (pictured below). There are two other major oil and gas refineries, three liquified natural gas (LNG) plants, two major toxic waste sites, a port, and many other petrochemical facilities. **Many of these facilities, including the Motiva and Valero Refineries, cluster in West Side Port Arthur.** In addition to these burdens, Port Arthur was the location one of Hurricane Harvey's landfalls. The city received the most rainfall of the storm event. Collectively, these underscore the confluence of climate and environmental injustices faced in this community.

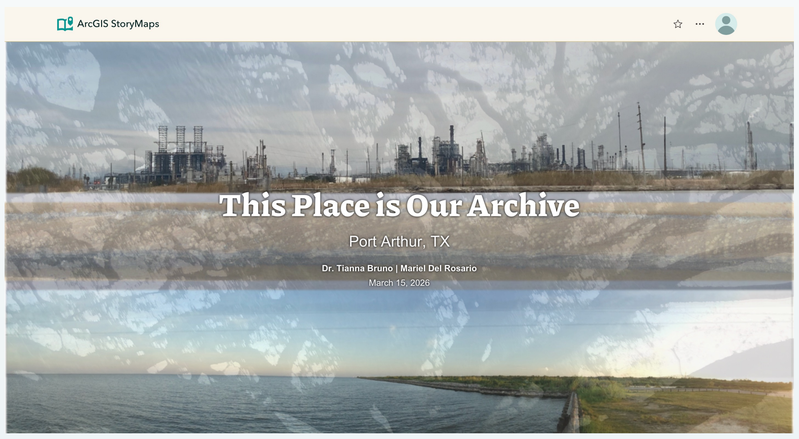


A bird flying over the refinery in West Side Port Arthur

Methodology

Using a combination of Port Arthur oral histories, Google MyMaps, ArcGIS StoryMaps, and video editing software, we are creating a **visual (and audio) depiction** of how Black relationships to place and environment developed in the West Side, and how the oil refineries and climate change complicate them.

1. **Organized and edited** multiple interviews conducted by Mr. John Syers Jr, the son of one of the first Black councilmen of Port Arthur, of Port Arthur residents, listening for the names and possible addresses of spaces that were meaningful to them.
2. **Sorted interviews** into a Box folder, which also contained hundreds of **documents** of information relating to Port Arthur.
3. Looked through **Google Maps and Streetview** to collect visuals of how West Side Port Arthur has changed over time.
4. **Google MyMap:** mapped these locations, dividing them into businesses, churches, residents, and schools.
5. **ArcGIS StoryMap:** includes the Google MyMap (soon), photos evidencing the loss of places in Port Arthur, and an introduction video by Mr. Syers.



The landing page of the storymap, with an image of the Motiva Refinery overlaid with sprawling branches of a tree as the background.

The Storymap

Ultimately, our storymap contains the following sections:

- **Introduction to Spaces Where There Were Places**
- **Spaces Where There Were Places**
- **Ecological Memories**

The first two sections illustrate the **loss** experienced in West Port Arthur through visuals and text. Ecological Memories focuses on the **historical ties Port Arthur has to the Middle Passage**, displaying markers commemorating this. This storymap will continue to grow as we uncover more histories and lived experiences, and will serve as an **archive of the vibrant Black community that has persisted in West Port Arthur.**



The leftover foundation of a building in West Side Port Arthur



An image of a lily flower in West Side Port Arthur, likely one of the only traces of a garden planted there years ago, with a sidecar introducing the Spaces Where There Were Places project by Mr. John Syers Jr

EJ scholarship has proven time and again that to live and love in a community facing environmental racism is to face loss, suffering, and death. Loss of hope in state protection. Loss of loved ones. Loss of land and sense of place. Loss of life and health. **But how can we behold Black livingness, relations to place, and futurity experienced insisted with in and in close proximity to loss and death in EJ communities?** This story map aims to foreground Black place relations within the context of environmental injustice and petrochemical dispossession, underscoring Black history and life in West Side over time. A place that's presently being lost, yet is worthy of being honored.



Nelson's Confectionary, a meaningful place mentioned in multiple interviews, in 2008 (left) vs 2024 (right) on Google Streetview as displayed on the storymap

Acknowledgments

Mr. John Syers Jr
The community of West Side Port Arthur, Texas
UC Berkeley Department of Geography

Contact Information

Dr. Tianna Bruno: tbruno@berkeley.edu
Mariel Del Rosario: marieltdr@berkeley.edu